

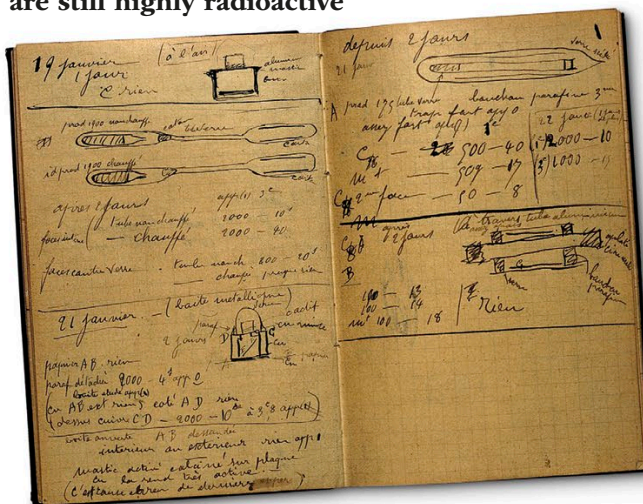
Marie Curie

One of the great scientists of her age, the Polish-French physicist Marie Curie was a pioneer in the study of radioactivity—the stream of energetic particles produced when unstable atoms break up. Her work improved our understanding of radioactivity, leading to the treatment of cancers with radiation. For her discoveries of two radioactive elements, she became the first person to be awarded two Nobel Prizes.

A WOMAN IN A MAN'S WORLD

In late 19th-century Europe, women were largely barred from the scientific world. In Curie's home country of Poland, women couldn't even attend college, forcing her to study in secret. Her career took off when she moved to Paris, France, where she gained degrees in both physics and chemistry. Curie's extraordinary achievements paved the way for other female scientists.

Marie Curie's notebooks are still highly radioactive



Uranium ore, from which polonium and radium are extracted



NEW ELEMENTS

When Curie arrived in Paris, scientists had recently discovered that certain elements, such as uranium, were radioactive. Working with her husband, the scientist Pierre Curie, and alone, she discovered two more radioactive elements, polonium and radium, in 1898.

TREATING CANCER

Curie's discoveries led to the development of radiotherapy—a method of treating cancer with high bursts of radiation. Unfortunately, the dangers of radiation were not well understood at the time and Curie is believed to have died from a bone disease caused by long-term exposure to radiation.



LITTLE CURIES

In World War I, Curie arranged for 20 trucks to be equipped with X-ray machines, which could be used to scan wounded soldiers for bullets and broken bones. She even helped to drive the trucks to the war zone herself. By the end of the war, these trucks, known as “Little Curies” (left), had examined more than a million soldiers.

1906

After Pierre's death in a street accident, Marie takes over his job as professor at Sorbonne University, becoming the first woman to hold such a position.

1910

Marie wins her second Nobel Prize in Chemistry. She is the only woman to have won two Nobel Prizes, and the only person to have won for different sciences.

1934

She dies at the age of 66, following a long period of illness believed to have been caused by prolonged exposure to radiation.

1995

The remains of Pierre and Marie are moved to the Panthéon in Paris, where the most distinguished French citizens are buried.